WORLD PUBLIC OPINION

It is widely acknowledged that world public opinion acts as an external restraint on the foreign policy decision-makers of any state. However, the effectiveness of the world public opinion of restraining a particular state from performing an action, which might violate international law and morality, is questionable. It is equally difficult to define and even harder to prove the existence of world public opinion.

Morgenthau has offered a definition which partially covers the element and extent of world public opinion. He states, “World public opinion is obviously a public opinion that transcends national boundaries and that unites members of different nations in a consensus with regard to at least certain fundamental international issues”. The question which arises is: Does such consensus exist and if so, can it be regarded as world public opinion? It is true that human beings have a desire for freedom, self-expression, self-development, and therefore, develop a certain perspective, opinions or expectations regarding certain fundamental aspects of foreign policy behaviour of states. It is hardly tenable that there is a tremendous psychological unity of the world and upon this psychological conviction, similar ethical postulates and political aspirations may be shared by all men under certain conditions. Most often this is not the case. This world is an unequal world with unequal distribution of power and great economic disparity dividing the globe into the haves and the have nots, the North and the South, the Developed World and the Third World, and so on. Even the same moral precepts may assume different meanings in different environments. As imperialism, racialism, colonialism, neo-colonialism and dependency might have different interpretations for the once colonial powers and the Third World, perceptions regarding some particular issues like the given ones may give rise to consensus among some groups of states which in most cases are driven by their common historical experiences and their struggle against particular actions of other groups of states, which for them might be exploitative and discriminatory. Earlier, such common perceptions had united a certain part of the world and given rise to